

HOUSE No. 2899

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

David Paul Linsky

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act relative to supporting social workers.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	DATE ADDED:
<i>David Paul Linsky</i>	<i>5th Middlesex</i>	<i>1/16/2025</i>
<i>James C. Arena-DeRosa</i>	<i>8th Middlesex</i>	<i>10/15/2025</i>
<i>Natalie M. Higgins</i>	<i>4th Worcester</i>	<i>10/15/2025</i>
<i>Rodney M. Elliott</i>	<i>16th Middlesex</i>	<i>10/15/2025</i>
<i>John Francis Moran</i>	<i>9th Suffolk</i>	<i>10/21/2025</i>
<i>James B. Eldridge</i>	<i>Middlesex and Worcester</i>	<i>12/2/2025</i>

HOUSE No. 2899

By Representative Linsky of Natick, a petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 2899) of David Paul Linsky relative to benefits for social workers. Public Service.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to supporting social workers.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. Section 3 of chapter 32 of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2022
2 Official Edition, is hereby amended by inserting, in line 277 , after the words “social worker
3 A/B, C, or D,;” the following words:- “clinical social worker A/B and C, social work technician,
4 special investigator 1/2, case reviewer, human service assistant, and human service coordinator”.

5 SECTION 2. Section 100 of Chapter 32 of Massachusetts General Laws, as so appearing,
6 is amended by adding at the end the following paragraph:-

7 “Effective January 1, 2025, social workers at the Department of Children and Families
8 shall be eligible for this benefit. The Massachusetts State Board of Retirement shall promulgate
9 regulations under which conditions a DCF social worker can be eligible.”

10 SECTION 3. Chapter 112 of the General Laws, as so appearing, is hereby amended by
11 inserting after section 135C the following section:-

“Section 135D. To ensure a stable, diverse workforce of licensed social workers in the Commonwealth of Massachusetts, and to provide for increased support and retention of practicing licensed social workers, the executive office of health and human services shall create and administer a field placement grant program. The program shall, subject to appropriation, provide grant funding to designated recipients with a specific focus on recruiting and retaining Masters of Social Work (MSW) students from historically marginalized communities and low-income communities. Funds to establish this program shall be allocated from state, federal, or other dedicated resources, including existing trust funds.”

Eligible applicants must attend a school of social work Masters program physically located in Massachusetts that has been accredited by the Council on Social Work Education.

To be eligible for consideration, applicants must submit the following:

(i) Applicant demographic background information, including, but not limited to, race, ethnicity, geographic location in the state, and date of birth for purposes of data collection;

(ii) Applicant’s school of social work, type of Masters program, and grade point average;

(iii) Applicant’s stated and signed commitment to working in Massachusetts post-graduation for at least 2 years; and

(iv) Applicant’s 1-page statement on the importance of this stipend in the applicant’s life and how the grant will support their educational goals and the workforce needs of the Commonwealth.

Priority for the field placement grant program shall go to first-generation college students and persons from currently underrepresented communities in the social worker profession.

Applications will be submitted and considered on a rolling basis between January 1st and no later than March 1st of each year. Recipients of stipends shall be notified no later than April 15th.

Stipends shall be allocated as follows:

(i) A current MSW student in good standing completing their first-year field placement of 16 hours per week shall be eligible for a monthly stipend of \$1,000 per month, not to exceed \$8,000 annually.

(ii) A current MSW student in good standing completing their second-year field placement of 24 hours per week shall be eligible for a monthly stipend of \$2,000 per month, not to exceed a total of \$16,000 annually.

(iii) Advanced standing students who are only required to conduct one field placement shall be eligible for the second-year field placement stipend.

Applicant data, including application details submitted, shall be tracked by the executive office so that the program efficacy can be evaluated.

SECTION 4. Section 136 of chapter 112 of the General Laws, as so appearing, is hereby amended by inserting after the fourth paragraph the following paragraph:

“At the time of license renewal, each applicant shall present satisfactory evidence that in the period since the license was issued, he has completed the continuing education requirements specified by the board. Under any circumstances, licensed independent clinical social workers engaged in the independent practice who provide one-on-one supervision to a licensed certified social worker, Masters of social work intern, or Bachelors of social work intern shall be credited

with up to 8 hours of continuing education for the renewal cycle in which the supervision was provided. The Board, through the promulgation of regulations, shall establish a process for recognition and application of continuing education hours based upon one-on-one supervision.”

SECTION 5. (a.) There shall be established a special commission to investigate the creation of a new certification for child welfare workers at the department of children and families.

(b) The commission shall consist of the house and senate chairs of the joint committee on children, families, and persons with disabilities who shall serve as co-chairs; one member appointed by the speaker of the House of Representatives; one member appointed by the president of the Senate; one member appointed by the minority leader of the House of Representatives; one member appointed by the minority leader of the house; the commissioner of the department of children and families, or their designee; the director of the office of the child advocate, or their designee; two members appointed by SEIU Local 509 who are current workers employed by the department of children and families and who have served at the department for over five years; two representatives of child or family welfare organizations from communities which are disproportionately involved with the department of children and families, appointed by the co-chairs; and two individuals previously personally involved with the department of children and families, appointed by the co-chairs; a representative of the Association of Social Work Boards and a representative of the National Association of Social Workers. All appointments shall be made not later than 60 days after the effective date of this act. The commission shall convene its first meeting not more than 90 days from the effective date of this act.

(c) The commission shall examine the feasibility and make recommendations regarding the creation of a new certification for child welfare workers at the department of children and families, including, without limitation: 1) whether social work licensure, as outlined in section 121 of chapter 112 of the general laws, is the only appropriate qualification to be a child welfare professional employed by the department of children and families; 2) explore the possibility of a new certification or form of licensure to be made available in addition to social work licensure, with training and education requirements specific to child protection and the work of the department of children and families; 3) consider what would qualify an individual for this new certification.

(d) The Commission shall, no later than fifteen months from the effective date of this act, report to the general court on the results of its investigation and study together with its finding, by filing the same with the clerks of the house of representatives and senate who shall forward the same to the secretary of the executive office of health and human services, the house and senate committees on ways and means, the joint committee on children, families, and persons with disabilities, and the joint committee on consumer protection and professional licensure.